

Help Online

The 'Support' section of your manufacturer's Web site can be a great source of comfort. Many sites offer comprehensive and even interactive support. You can even seek help from other independent sites where experts are more than glad to solve your PC-related woes.

Microsoft Help and Support

Queries related to Windows can be asked at the Microsoft global product support site, where the support section provides access to a searchable knowledge base, software and hardware FAQs, the latest patches and updates, apart from online support requests.

<http://support.microsoft.com>

Ask-a-Tech

Just post a question on this site and one of the site volunteers will e-mail you an answer. There is also a bulletin board where you can post a question and separate forums are provided for hardware, software, Microsoft products, Linux and Internet related queries.

www.ask-a-tech.org

AskMe

AskMe pairs experts and novices to answer and ask questions. The computer forums are quite active and you can get answers to your questions within a few hours.

www.askme.com

Experts Exchange

A huge community of IT professionals offer free consultation on a wide variety of topics, from programming to networking on this site. There's also a search engine facility for scouring past questions.

www.experts-exchange.com

Tech Guy

This site has a very active forum, which covers a good range of subjects. The best way to get a solution is to search past posts, where you are bound to find someone who has dealt with your crisis before.

<http://forums.techguy.org>

Windows Annoyances

This site has won various awards for its unique Windows-related troubleshooting articles and features. It has unique tips and tweaks to get your PC singing.

www.annoyances.org

On-Call', where technically trained staff receive customer calls and resolve queries over the phone for the entire range of Compaq products.

According to Sampath, 80 per cent of PC-related woes stem from Internet connectivity, OS problems and virus attacks. His tech support centre, called Sam 7, is based in south Mumbai and services an average of 50 calls a day. "IBM and Dell have a huge call centre network, but all these calls are strictly hardware calls and there is no software support except for Windows. Our company scores by servicing operating system, networking and virus-related calls."

If your computer is not under any warranty or an annual maintenance contract (AMC), try taking it to a local repair shop or support service centre around your area.

You can even search for freelance help by going through the classifieds in the newspaper. PC Doctor, a team of certified professionals based in Mumbai, Pune and Bangalore, provide on-site troubleshooting services for a reasonable price of Rs 375 per visit. Other similar services charge an average of Rs 250 to Rs 400 per visit. Good freelance help may be hard to find, but there's always someone who knows someone who is very good with the PC.

If you are really concerned about your computer and use it for a home-based business or a small company, then it is advisable to get an extended warranty or AMC. A comprehensive AMC would cover all hardware and software problems and would guarantee replacement in case of a component malfunction. A cheaper, non-comprehensive contract would only cover all your software related issues.

Post disaster measures

A hard drive crash can be crippling, as in the case of Jayant, who runs a SoHo (Small office/Home office) business called Om Investments, based in Mumbai. All his valuable office data, e-mails and contacts were lost when his hard drive crashed. Fortunately for him, it was a logical error and all the data was recovered.

Manoj Dhingra, Technical Director of Stellar Information Systems, a company specialising in hard drive data recovery, spoke about the nature of problems

experienced by users. According to him, logical crashes account for 85 per cent of the total hard drive crashes, 13 per cent are due to physical crashes and the remaining 2 per cent are considered natural disasters.

"It is difficult to estimate the life of any hard drive, but hard drives made before 1995 have a longer life than the ones found in the market nowadays. Which is why backing up your data is really important," says Manoj.

Help yourself

While most vendors help you with hardware and component level problems, there are many problems that they can't fix at the software level. This is when every PC-owner has to do some personal R&D, mess with the BIOS settings, tweak the system, and get their hands dirty.



Sampath Iyengar
PROPRIETOR, SAM 7

“Since we aren't a branded service centre, our success depends on word-of-mouth and customer references, which are stronger than cold calls”

Simply downloading the latest drivers for your hardware and installing them can fix a lot of things. It's a good idea to update and install the latest patches for your operating system regularly, as is checking the manufacturer's site for FAQs and troubleshooting advice. Sometimes a new software that seems unrelated to the problem could have caused the crash to begin with. Read the manual that comes with your motherboard thoroughly for issues and incompatibilities with the rest of your system. A BIOS setting or just a faulty connection might be the culprit. Check all the connections (IDE cables, printer cables, phone cords); by doing this you may fix the problem by fixing a bad connection.

You can fix many bugs all by yourself and though troubleshooting a computer can be a real nightmare, it's not rocket science! Best of all, it's a confidence boosting experience, and once you get it right, you'll be able to get your PC up and running on your own, ever after. In the meantime, don't feel shy to ask the right people for help!

SRIRAM SHARMA